



year or the latter with Kuldeep in Ranchi in the same series, the lower-order has been instrumental in waging inspirational fightbacks. Ashwin and Axar's 114-run stand in Delhi and Jadeja and Axar in Nagpur were also key in subduing Australia last year.

When India last faced Bangladesh in the latter's backyard in late 2022, it was again the lower-order that saved the team the blushes. Ashwin joined

forces with Shreyas Iyer for an unbroken eighth-wicket partnership, worth 71 runs, to eke out a three-wicket win in Mirpur, while the first Test in that series saw Ashwin and Kuldeep stitch 87 runs for the eighth wicket in Chattogram to help India to 404 in the first innings in challenging conditions.

In what were billed as India's toughest challenges at home in the last two years, the lower-order

Rocking rearguard: Ashwin and Jadeja's lower-order batting resilience has helped India maintain its dominant home record in Test cricket. AP